
The miracle workers of pacifism

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*The miracle workers of pacifism**

Agathon

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There are those for whom war is one of the necessities in the life of peoples, one of the most formidable, one that we must always wish to avoid as a very great evil but which occasionally we must accept as a lesser danger. Such persons are very common. They are peaceful; they are not pacifists. The appellation of pacifist requires a higher level of culture. Scarcely sure that we possess this to the required degree, we wish today, in commemoration of the Bern Congress, to let the most notorious pacifists speak, so that they may present their views themselves.

It was in 1907, a few months after the first threats from Germany. War was on the cards. Thus the Société de philosophie put on the agenda 'the problem of pacifism'. That assembly, as one knows, brings together the holders of chairs in philosophy and the most important professors of the Sorbonne, in short, all that represents thought, 'the body of thinkers'. On December 30, there were a score of erudite scholars¹ in little Room D, in the Faculty of Letters, gathered to *reason* about peace and *patrie*. Their words might have been lost, but the *Bulletin* of the society has preserved for us a memorable stenographic record (pp. 31-70).

The notorious M. Ruyssen, professor in the Faculty of Letters of Bordeaux, expounded [the doctrine] of out-and-out pacifism and developed his historical and legal conception of war.

There was nothing save what was commonplace in this thesis, made familiar in many public meetings; and M. Ruyssen expounded it without verve. The session only came alive at the moment when M. Durkheim opened the discussion.

M. Durkheim began to speak as a resolute patriot. He declared 'that in one sense anti-patriotism has always seemed to be a veritable absurdity.' But in what sense? In the sense that 'no one can live outside organized society',

*Agathon, 'Avant-Postes. Articles 1910-13'. First published in *Paris-Journal*. Reproduced in *Cahiers d'Occident*, pp. 98-104. [Much of the extensive underlining has been omitted in translation].

namely some kind of *patrie*, his own or another, 'the *Patrie* of Europe, or the *Patrie* of humanity.' This is one of those 'laws' highlighted, after much effort and research, by modern sociology.

Having taken these precautions against the accusation of anti-patriotism, M. Durkheim goes on, in an assured tone: 'Only, there is another problem whose solution is less easy: *it is to know what kind of patrie we should desire!*'

Gravitas befits philosophical discussions. There they are, seated around a green baize table, twenty masters of thought, illustrious with titular and doctoral honours, men of authority to whom common opinion ascribes intelligence and seriousness, and who have not gathered together to laugh. And this is the subject of their research: *What sort of patrie should we desire?*'

They are alone, among colleagues, among scholars, isolated from all contingent affairs, immersed in pure abstractions of the mind, assembled in an international place, to wit a room of the Sorbonne. And the universe anxiously waits to know what *patrie* they ought to want.

Immediately M. Ruyssen answers heatedly: 'Personally, I think our preference must go less to the *patrie* of today than that of the *patrie* of the future.' (p. 44)

M. Durkheim is not satisfied; he insists on more preciseness:

'To what extent,' he says, 'ought we to express a wish *for our patrie* against and above all others? To what extent should we desire that other *patrie* that is still only an ideal, but an ideal which, however, is in the process of being realized?' (p. 45).

Then M. Ruyssen, harassed by such compelling logic, makes up his mind and bravely abandons his *patrie*:

'For my part, I do not hesitate: the greatest truth lies in internationalism. I believe our countries should be integrated into an ever greater entity. *Patrie* has already lost several of its constituents, such as the religious element; it will lose still more, without our being able to foresee with certainty where this disintegration will end.' (p. 45)

A long drawn-out silence follows this catastrophic suggestion. At that moment a timid voice is raised: 'I am no philosopher, I am a politician, a man of goodwill. I have been following with great attention this interesting discussion...For my part, I am absolutely of the view that countries must be preserved.' (p. 48)

This was M. d'Estournelles de Constant. Alas, he is only expressing a personal opinion! M. Durkheim reminds this unusual parliamentarian, who lacks any credentials, that he is among 'philosophers'.

'Do you therefore believe, sir, that history can come to a stop?' (p. 48).

To halt history, as Joshua halted the sun, had d'Estournelles de Constant been capable of thinking it?

Stirred by this prophetic vision, gesticulating with his long, thin arms and shirt-cuffs, and standing up in the room, M. Durkheim continues:

'Why should this historic movement that has been proceeding in the same direction for centuries, why should it suddenly come to a halt when confronted with our present-day countries? What is there especially elusive that prevents it going farther? I wonder whether true pacifism does not consist of our doing our very best for this movement to continue, but peacefully and no longer by violence and war, as was the rule that prevailed in the past.' (p. 50).

After these words, with their promise of peace, optimism spreads over the whole room, and these innocent pedagogues bask in the image of an idyllic universe, untroubled by war, from which rude soldiery would be banished and military men would be of service only at jubilee celebrations of great professors. They drink in the ideal.

One onlooker keeps his sense of reality in this state of professorial delirium. With semi-ironical, semi-respectful caution, a parliamentarian admonishes these ideologues:

'You must forgive me,' says M. Ferdinand Buisson, 'but perhaps I have missed the point. Doubtless I am going outside the field of the discussion. Throughout this debate, while listening to you, I was transposing our words and trying to apply them in a different context. I was following up the same problem by placing it in a more narrow framework, where it appears more related to people, but perhaps one more profound.'

'The conflict of ideas you are talking about, I envisioned in the form of a modern young man, for example, one of those young anti-militarists whom we put in prison. There the two ideas that a little while ago we have opposed to the theoretical viewpoint, are also opposed, but...in a concrete, personal shape that borders on the acute, and occasionally on the tragic. In this lies the poignancy of the discussion.' (pp. 58-59).

No one responds to this common-sense reflection, which contrasts so strongly with the solemn disputation of a little while ago. A feeling of embarrassment, confusion and sadness puts a stop to words. And pessimism and resignation will mark all words spoken from now on. This is because

each individual within himself goes back over the past and consults his own experiences. All those revolutionaries of the mixed-up kind, as Péguy says, all these 'social' bourgeois, as they style themselves, think back to the time when they had hope in the moral energy of the people. Had they not imagined that their own role, they the professors, the philosophers and university teachers, was to reveal to the people the true social doctrine? But the militant proletariat had rudely made them understand that it wanted to educate itself. What it has retained of the class struggle 'as indefatigably taught it by the intellectuals of socialism, has been about what a war was, or what it would be, or more exactly a military war'. O horror! These bourgeois pacifists have taught war!

And now they lament, disconcerted, discouraged and saddened at their impotence. The violence of the populace, its confused agitation, unnerves their bourgeois cosmopolitanism.

Anxiously M. Parodi asks: 'How can the people's simplistic view be brought to admit the need for some kind of *patrie* or another?'

M. Durkheim replies: 'It is certain that one can hardly achieve this through normal apologetics. The best way to defend the idea of *patrie* is too often believed to be to demonstrate how greatly our *patrie* is worthy of our love. One extols the virtues of French culture, the superiority of democracy, etc., etc. This is to assume a very bad position.'

However, M. Ruysen persists in seeing no other solution than pacifism to reconcile the people, and he expresses it as follows:

'At the present time there is already a conflict between two *patries*, the actual one and the one of the future, which is still vague, but to which one feels all the more attached when one is more detached from the other *patrie*. Now, this conflict between two types of *Patrie*, even within the present *Patrie*, is a reason for favouring pacifism. Peoples must be spared those terrible cases of conscience that wars between civilized peoples represent. And this is an additional reason to work with pacifism to create progressive laws in which the normal evolution of countries can develop effectively and peacefully.' (p. 62).

But there is a reason even more decisive, for the necessity of pacifism that should suffice to convince the most rebellious:

'Recently,' says M. Ruysen, 'the Universal Peace Congress has had, in the heart of Germany, a striking success. The Germans, the citizens of Munich, showed themselves very struck by it, very impressed. But suppose now that at a critical moment panic grips some minds, and that mass resignations thin out the ranks of French pacifism, they will immediately say

in Germany: the pacifism of the French is not serious, there is no foundation to it!' (p. 63).

M. Bouglé, rendered more sceptical by his contact with the People's Universities and election meetings, shakes his head. He doubts whether the working-class, only enthusiastic about negations, would ever grasp the idea of *patrie*, and with imprudent vivacity, this *enfant terrible* exclaims: 'There are moments, however pacifist one may be, when one feels one is again becoming bellicose.'

Sacrilege! M. Durkheim leaps up:

'The word bellicose, sir, that you have just pronounced doubtless went beyond what you were thinking.'

And through its silence, the whole room seems to censure the accursed word.

However, the discussion livens up again and all agree that 'it is impossible to get one's ideas over in a violent environment.' Will they therefore abandon the people?

M. Rauh consents to this not at all. He takes up once again the proposition whereby the latent nationalism of certain pacifists is revealed; for him the success of internationalist ideas is the success of French ideas.

'Our own role, we "social" bourgeois', he says, 'is to show that our *patrie* should be maintained in its present form, in order to safeguard that French mentality that the revolutionaries, like us, acknowledge.' (p. 65).

This corruption of pure, abstract pacifism in no way escapes M. Durkheim who, like Diaforus, follows a line of reasoning 'to the utmost limits of logic':

'Is it not to speak the language of nationalism', he says, 'to place French culture above all others, even if under the banner of revolution? It would be a matter for despair if one were condemned to patriotism only by placing France above all else: One must make one's *patrie* loved *in abstracto* without making this especially prized sentiment depend on its attachment to French culture.' (p. 69).

Faced with such fine-sounding texts, every commentary fades into nothing. Would that Molière were still alive! We dedicate these true statements, which bear the hallmark of the natural, to certain present-day playwrights for whom pacifists are still grave characters whose thoughts are serious.

We would perhaps have found them less ridiculous a few years ago. Today, after the harsh lesson of the facts, they appear to us what they are: solemn, bookish, and somewhat buffoonish.² When we have read, as tidied up

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by them, the record of their work, we can understand better the meaning and purport of the petition against the three-year law that they have dreamed up and put together. Neither M. Durkheim, nor M. Bouglé, nor the others could find fault with this small labour of exegesis, which, making known the 'religion' of these gentlemen, will enlighten that of our readers.

(Translated by W. D. Halls)

NOTES

1. Among university staff present were: Beaulavon, Belot, Borel, Bouglé, Brunschvicg, Cantecor, Couturat, Cresson, Desjardins, Dunan, Durkheim, Jacob, Lachelier, Parodi, Rauh.
2. Not much later they would appear as criminally irresponsible.